

If you know these 15 C2-level words, your English is expert level!

This ultimate vocabulary challenge tests your knowledge of 15 incredibly advanced C2-level words and phrases. You need to have an expert level of English to know what they all mean! Through three progressively challenging rounds, you'll discover vocabulary that separates good English speakers from truly exceptional ones. Master these incredibly advanced terms to sound more articulate in any English-speaking environment.

Question 1:

Choose the correct definition for the word in bold.

- "The kids keep **hassling** us to get a dog."
- a) to repeatedly annoy somebody, often by asking them to do something many times
- b) to hurry or rush somebody

to hassle (v) /'hæsl/

The correct definition for **hassle** is **a) to repeatedly annoy somebody**. You'll often see the structure to hassle somebody to do something, like we have in the example sentence, or to hassle someone for something.

Question 2:

Choose the correct definition for the term in bold.

- "Let's just get the main bullet points down for now - we can **flesh out** the ideas later."

- a) to add more detail or information to something
- b) to let people know about something

to flesh out (phr. v) /ˌfleʃˈaʊt/

The correct answer is **a) to add more detail or information to something**. We often talk about fleshing out **ideas**, **details** and **plans**.

Question 3:

Choose the correct definition for the phrase in bold.

- "Her excuse about the dog eating her homework just **doesn't hold water**."

- a) not believable or convincing
- b) not creative or inventive enough

not hold water (idiom) /nɒt həʊld 'wɔ:tə/

The answer is **a) not believable or convincing**. So, if something doesn't hold water, it's not believable or convincing. We often use it with nouns such as **excuse**, **statement** and **argument**.

Question 4:

Choose the correct definition for the phrase in bold.

- "That 12-hour flight has left my body clock totally **out of kilter**."

- a) experiencing jet lag for the first time

b) not working properly or in its usual state

out of kilter (idiom) /aʊt əv 'kɪltə/

The correct answer is **b) not working properly or in its usual state**. We can also use this idiom to mean that 2 things do not agree with or match each other, for example:

- "The government's policy is **out of kilter** with public opinion."

Notice the preposition there: out of kilter *with* something.

Question 5:

Choose the correct definition for the phrase in bold.

- "She was trying to help, but her suggestions just **muddied the waters**."

a) to make a simple situation more complicated and less clear than it was before

b) to bring hidden problems to the surface

to muddy the waters (idiom) /'mʌdi ðə 'wɔ:təz/

The correct answer is **a) to make a simple situation more complicated and less clear than it was before**. I love how visual this idiom is - let me explain.



If you muddy the waters, you add mud to water and make it less transparent, less clear. You can muddy the waters both intentionally and unintentionally. Notice how we use the plural - muddy the waters. We also say **muddy the issue**.

Question 6:

Which word best completes the sentence?

- "Let's just split the bill 4 ways - it's not worth _____ over a few pounds."

- a) quibbling
- b) niggling
- c) quivering

The correct answer is **a) quibbling**.

to quibble (v) /'kwɪbl/

This means **to argue or complain about small, unimportant details**. We quibble over or about something. It's often a number or an amount.

to niggle /'nɪgl/

(of a doubt, feeling or pain) to cause slight but continuous discomfort or worry

- "A sense of guilt began to **niggle** at him."

to quiver /'kwɪvə/

to shake slightly, often because of strong emotion

- "His lip began to **quiver** and he looked like he was about to cry."

Question 7:

Which word best completes the sentence?

- "The twins exchanged _____ glances across the dinner table, which made their parents suspicious they were up to no good."

- a) fussy
- b) furtive
- c) frail

The correct answer is **b) furtive**.

furtive (adj) /'fɜ:tɪv/

Furtive is an adjective used to describe **suspicious or secretive behaviour**. It collocates strongly with the nouns **glance** and **look**.

frail /freɪl/

physically weak or delicate, especially because of age or illness

- "She looked too **frail** to walk without support.

fussy /'fʌsi/

too concerned about having things exactly right; hard to please

- "He's so **fussy** about how his clothes are folded."

Question 8:

Which word best completes the sentence?

- "I don't find the prospect of camping in a field for a week in this terrible weather particularly _____."

- a) alluring
- b) alluding
- c) enduring

The answer is **a) alluring**.

alluring (adj) /ə'luəriŋ/

This means **attractive or exciting**. A less formal alternative that would work well in this sentence is **appealing**.

- "I don't find the idea of camping in the rain **appealing**."

"Alluring" collocates strongly with words like **prospect** and **offer**, but we also use it to talk about a **person's attractiveness**, for example, an alluring **smile**, **scent** or **voice**.

to allude (to sth.) /ə'lu:d/

to mention something in an indirect or subtle way

- "She **alluded** to her past without giving any details."

to endure /ɪn'djʊə/

to suffer something difficult or unpleasant patiently, or to continue despite hardship

- "They had to **endure** long hours of uncomfortable travel."

Question 9:

Which word best completes the sentence?

- "That last question completely _____ me - I didn't have a clue how to answer!"

- a) flattered
- b) duped
- c) flummoxed

The answer is **c) flummoxed**.

to flummox (v) /'flʌməks/

To flummox means **to confuse somebody so much that they don't know what to do or say**.

We also often say to leave someone or be left flummoxed, for example:

- "That last question left me completely **flummoxed**."
- "I was left utterly **flummoxed** by the packet instructions."

to flatter /'flætə/

to praise someone in a way that is not always sincere, often to gain favour

- "He **flattered** his boss to try to get a promotion."

to dupe /dju:p/

to trick or deceive someone into believing or doing something

- "Scammers **duped** her into revealing her bank details."

Question 10:

Which word best completes the sentence?

- "Don't listen to her - what she's saying is a load of old _____."

- a) rigmarole
- b) hogwash
- c) pragmatism

The correct answer is **b) hogwash** - not to be confused with Hogwarts!

hogwash (n) /'hɒgwɒʃ/

It's an informal noun for **an idea or talk that is stupid**. **Nonsense** and **rubbish** have similar meanings in this context. It collocates well with the adjectives **absolute**, **complete** and **pure**.

rigmarole /'rɪgmərəʊl/

a long, complicated, and often pointless process or set of instructions

- "We had to go through the usual **rigmarole** of filling in endless forms."

pragmatism /'prægmətɪzəm/

a practical approach to problems and situations focused on results

- "His decision to postpone the trip showed a sense of **pragmatism**."



Question 11:

Do you know the meaning of the word in bold?

- "Leaving your dog at home alone all day is **tantamount** to cruelty."

tantamount (adj) /'tæntəmaʊnt/

We always use this adjective in the structure **tantamount to something** and it means **the same or virtually the same as**. It's generally used to say something has the same or almost the same effect as something bad. Another example:

- "Copying another student's work is **tantamount** to stealing."

Copying another student's work is equivalent to or nearly equivalent to stealing.

Question 12:

Do you know the meaning of the word in bold?

- "The doctor advised me to refrain from any **strenuous** exercise in the weeks after my operation."

strenuous (adj) /'strenjuəs/

If something is strenuous, it **requires a lot of effort and energy**, for example strenuous **exercise, activity or work**. We can also use it more figuratively to mean determined, for example:

- "The company is making **strenuous** efforts to cut its carbon emissions."

Question 13:

Do you know the meaning of the word in bold?

- "The internet has made it easier than ever to **propagate** misinformation."

to **propagate** (v) /'prɒpəgeɪt/

Here's another word with a couple of meanings. In this context, to propagate means **to spread**. It's often used with nouns like **a message, an agenda or an ideology**. It often has a negative connotation to describe the spread of hateful ideas, beliefs and lies.

The second meaning is much more positive! Have you ever had a go at propagating your plants? This is when you **take cuttings from a parent plant to grow new plants**. For example:

- "You can easily **propagate** pothos by cutting the stem and placing it in water."

Question 14:

Do you know the meaning of the term in bold?

- "The builder did such a **shoddy** job installing the kitchen cabinets - half of them didn't close properly."

shoddy adj /'ʃɒdi/

This means **poor quality work, done carelessly, badly or cheaply**. If we describe goods as shoddy, they're made with low-quality materials or have been badly or carelessly made.

Question 15:

Do you know the meaning of the word in bold?

- "It was a **nefarious** scheme, designed to trick people into giving up their bank details."

nefarious (adj) /nə'feəriəs/

Nefarious means **morally bad, evil or wicked**. We often use it to describe criminal acts.



Quiz

For each question, choose the correct answer from the options provided.

1. Choose the correct definition for the word in bold.

"My boss keeps **hassling** me about finishing the project early."

- a) to repeatedly annoy somebody by asking them to do something
- b) to hurry or rush somebody through something

2. Which word best completes the sentence?

"We have the basic outline ready, but we still need to _____ the details before the presentation."

- a) hold water
- b) muddy the waters
- c) flesh out

3. Complete the sentence with the correct word.

"The new software interface completely _____ our IT team on the first day."

- a) flattered
- b) flummoxed
- c) duped

4. Choose the word that best fits the context.

"The job offer in Antarctica wasn't very _____ despite the high salary."

- a) alluring
- b) furtive
- c) strenuous

5. Complete the sentence.

"Spreading rumours about your colleagues is _____ to workplace bullying."

- a) shoddy
- b) nefarious
- c) tantamount

6. Is this sentence correct or incorrect?

"Why are you quibbling over a couple of dollars? It's not worth it."

- a) Correct
- b) Incorrect

7. Is this sentence correct or incorrect?

"The CEO's comments only served to muddy the milk during the crisis."

- a) Correct
- b) Incorrect

8. Choose the correct word to complete the sentence.

"The criminals developed a _____ plan to steal money from people."

- a) furtive
- b) nefarious
- c) shoddy

Answers:

1.b 2.c 3.b 4.a 5.c 6.b 7.b 8.b

